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Onions are my husband

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School attendance generally prevents a youngster from contributing enough labor to receive the full benefits of assistantship, either in training or capital rights. Public primary and middle schools in Kumasi operated on double shifts that mitigated this conflict. Children could attend one shift and work essentially full time, although at some cost to their schoolwork. Secondary school was the major threshold, usually involving boarding and always substantial homework. This meant that some of the more successful traders, who had educated all of their own daughters, chose apprentices and a commercial heir from among more distant relatives. Poorer traders said they avoided educated girls as assistants, fearing they would prove disrespectful and unreliable. On the other hand, poor employment prospects send many girls back into market trading after secondary school. School attendance may have delayed their trading progress, but it improved their access to more profitable commodity lines than their mothers'.

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Distinguishing between the remuneration and conditions of work of kin and non-kin assistants becomes more difficult because of terminology which seems deliberately ambiguous. Local usage of terms referring to trading assistants avoids distinguishing baldly between status categories, even when more specific, accurate terms are available in Twi. The commonest term, *akwadaa* (young person or child), does not even separate trading assistants from other children. Asantes commonly use it around the house to avoid distinguishing between one's own children and neighbor children, foster children, maids, and young visitors. Teachers use it of their pupils, especially in boarding schools. In practice, using such a general term in description or reference draws discreet attention to the fact that no more positive term

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applies. Traders would introduce daughters and nieces with the more specific word *ba*, for one's own or one's sister's child, adding that "she helps me."

In general use, *akwadaa* has the connotation of inexperience and lack of knowledge, but also the positive qualities of confidence and energy associated with youth (Owusu 1992). This was also the term used for apprentices or trainees in precolonial craft workshops, who were not always relatives, and it places the senior trader in a benevolent, paternalistic light. Traders with numerous associates wanting to refer to all of them will use this term to include close relatives, former assistants,  198 and even adult traders who work with their capital. The last group would be particularly insulted to hear the term applied to them as individuals, even when they are the age of the speakers' actual sons or daughters; they respond with joking and teasing when within earshot.

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